

CASHING ON IT: Siddi dancers perform in Indore



Dancing for the Dough

East African by origin and Indian by destiny, Siddis use an age-old religious dance form to make a living

■ **By Ambreesh Mishra**

The native beat of the performance is unmistakably African, as are the rhythm, attire and war-painted features of the performers. It's their language—a smattering of Gujarati and Hindi—that's the dead giveaway. East African by origin and Indian by destiny for almost a millennium, the Siddi tribe that inhabits mostly the west coast from Gujarat to Karnataka, in small and secluded settlements is now trying to capture popular imagination.

After dwelling on the sidelines for ages, some Siddi youth have turned their religious dance into a hit show on the folk cultural circuit. The runaway success of *Siddi Dhamal*, as the dance performance is called, at the Malwa Utsav in Indore last month, bears testimony to this fact. Theirs was the only troupe forced to perform daily at the folk arts and craft festival on popular demand. *Siddi Dhamal* is a regular feature at many Navratri festivals, from Indore to Mumbai. The dance is a tribute paid to the medieval saint Hazrat Baba Gaur Mubaraq revered by the Siddi folk on the 11th lunar day in the month of Rajab (August-September).

The troupe members, aged between 16 and 28, now look at it as a way of breaking out of the cycle of poverty and deprivation. Says Zakir, a 24-year-old Siddi performer, "As



long as people like it, it doesn't matter whether the performance has religious origin or not." To exploit the dance form commercially, some Siddi youth have adopted African-sounding names like Danny Myava. Zakir feels they could deliver even better performance with girls joining in as they do during the Urs festival. However, they have avoided including

girls so far as they fear that the crowds may turn unruly. Says Rumana Ben Siddi, the 56-year-old matriarch of the group, "I am a little uneasy about commercialising the dance. But we can't help it as the boys hardly have any other career option."

The group has made dozens of national and international appearances, thanks to the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR). The exposure is doing the performers a world of good. Teenagers like Barkat, 16, are beginning to think of other careers like serving the Indian armed forces, something unthinkable for their previous generations. It's ironical, as many of the tribe, which first arrived in India in the 11th century, were hired warriors.

While Siddis have many other battles to fight on the social and economic fronts, the popularity of their dance raises hope that it will provide the tribe the much needed thrust to move up the development ladder. ■